temples and the British administration, but such misrepresentation of the past, wilful or through ignorance, appears to me to extend right across the board, not only on the internet and the media but also in some academic circles (and, as I emphasised in my Preface, history writing should never be taken at face value without asking where it's coming from). But the real issue, surely, is our natural preference for comforting mythology over uncomfortable history. This is as much an issue in the US and the UK as it is in India, but India, I believe, is something of a special case.

India has a vast and truly wonderful corpus of mythological literature that extends far beyond the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana* to include thousands of lesser-known works in Sanskrit, Tamil and other languages, all set within religious frameworks, whether Vedic, Brahministic, Shaiva, Vaishnava, Buddhist or Jain. This corpus is far richer and far more varied than the entire mythologies of Europe put together. Indeed, what we have in the British Isles is so pitiful that we have had to borrow most of our mythology from our continental neighbours and from the classics of Greece, Rome and the Levant, so that their gods have become ours.

But that is only half the picture, because what Britain had from an early age is historiography – again, entirely thanks to the Classical world.[5] That is rather a crude comparison, but my point is that just as the one culture has elevated the historical at the cost of the mythical, so the other has done the exact opposite.

This apparent difference in national attitudes was first noted by South India's Robert Caldwell, who observed that 'It is a singular fact that the Hindus, though fond of philosophy and poetry, of law, mathematics, and architecture, of music and the drama, and especially of religious or theosophical speculations and disquisitions, seem never to have cared anything of history. The original